After the verdict, in a statement on social media, Ratan expressed his gratitude for the outcome that he felt vindicated the objectivity and fairness that characterizes the Indian judiciary. He also said, ‘It is not an issue of winning or losing. After relentless attacks on my integrity and the ethical conduct of the group, the judgment upholding all the appeals of Tata Sons is a validation of the values and ethics that have always been the guiding principles of the group.’

Mistry, however, refused to accept the order. He filed a review petition in April 2021. The court heard it and after a year of the filing of the petition, in May 2022, it gave its decision. It refused to entertain the petition, saying: ‘We are satisfied that no case for review of judgment dated 26.03.2021 has been made out.’ Mistry was also directed to withdraw some objectionable statements he had made in his petition. Incidentally, the court also expunged some remarks it had made against Mistry in the order.

But some who were employed by Mistry when he was chairman, Tata Sons, continued to defend him, despite the unanimous decision of the apex court in favour of Ratan, Tata Sons and Tata Trusts. The saga came to an abrupt end when, in an unfortunate turn of events, Mistry passed away in a road accident on 4 September 2022.

Speaking to me some months after the May 2022 Supreme Court judgment, Ratan said that the decision vindicated Tata Trusts’ long-held position that as the 66 per cent owner, it and the Tata Sons’ board have the authority to decide who should lead the holding company. He commented with immense satisfaction that, with the judgment of the apex court, it had now been settled that a chairperson could also be replaced if the majority shareholder was of the opinion that he or she was not taking the companies in a ‘particular direction’.

But the five-year-long legal battle had taken its toll on Ratan’s heath. As Ronen Sen told me: ‘I am sad that unfounded professional allegations and disgraceful personal slurs’ were made against Ratan; the cut was so deep that it even ‘seem[s] to have irretrievably ruined Ratan’s health during the litigation’.

Ratan paid a huge personal price for the values he is sworn to and to safeguard the Trusts. The personal attacks on him, a man who has no heir and no next of kin or relative to benefit from his legal victory, but only the marginalized and needy who benefit from the income the Trusts earn, was unwarranted and wounded him deeply.